

# Authorial Presence and Originality: Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus*

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## Introduction

Albert Camus (1913-1960) was a French Algerian writer who had a profound impact on various philosophical disciplines. He made something of himself despite his impoverished upbringing, becoming an important journalist who wrote many pieces for revolutionary movements and won a Nobel Prize in Literature at the same time. Nonetheless, although Camus's story is an interesting one, what truly makes him special is his work's originality and authorial presence. Originality refers to ideas or narratives that are either entirely new or a reimagining of an existing idea. In Camus's case, it involves his ability to present theories that feel fresh and unheard of. Authorial presence describes the patterns that authors follow in their writing style, such as choices in diction or consistencies in language use. Camus authored numerous novels; however, *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) is the one that represents his authorial presence and writing originality best. But it is important to note that he wrote all his works exclusively in French, so an English translation was chosen for this essay's analysis.

## Authorial presence and originality

In this novel, Camus's ideas are intricate, and he chooses to explain them in a distinct manner. His diction tends to appear elevated and archaic. He also chooses to use sophisticated phrases that create an existential and philosophical atmosphere for his readers. "Whence" and "vigil of the mind" exemplify this atmosphere (Camus 65). According to historical etymology, whence was used 6.5 times per million in 1942. In 1800, it was used 71.6 times and, in 2019, it was used 4.7 times ("Whence"). "Vigil of the mind" is a more nuanced way of describing a profoundly conscious and aware mental state, and Camus used this phrase to describe an elaborate paradox that involves accepting the universe for what it is, an unrelenting force that cares not for humans and their trivial life purposes. Additionally, Camus states, "If it must encounter a night, let it be rather that of despair," a, for lack of better words, "refined" expression. He could have stated something simple like "if it faces night, let it be one of despair." Instead, he prioritized sophistication over clarity.

Camus opts to use a casual tone even though the elevated vocabulary he uses deceives his readers into perceiving a formal tone. For example, he affirms, "People are sufficiently annoyed (or that smile of complicity that debases what it admires) by Don Juan's speeches and by that same remark that he uses on all women. But to anyone who seeks quantity in his joys, the only thing that matters is efficacy" (Camus, 71). The words "sufficiently," "remark," "quantity," and "seeks" and the phrase "that smile of complicity that debases what it admires" resemble a formal tone. They are astute in nature and at a higher reading level. Regardless, he starts a new sentence with "But," uses the words "people" and "annoyed," and writes in longer clauses, all of which

resemble a casual, conversational tone. This casual tone is fundamental to Camus's writing. Therefore, it outweighs the formal façade readers receive.

Finally, the last aspect that makes Camus's authorial presence distinct is his use of voice. He adopts an active voice to make his prose direct and assertive. This sort of practice is only natural, as he needs to reassert that his essay's purpose is to confront the human psyche throughout the whole of his work, and this can be difficult when exhibiting multiple ideas at once. An active voice also reflects security and confidence in his writing. A prime example of this is arguably Camus's most widely known statement, "One must imagine Sisyphus happy" (Camus, 123). One, the individual examining Sisyphus's story, is given a direct action to emphasize how important it is that those who follow Camus's vision think with conviction.

Thus, Camus's authorial presence is recognizable by writing that is needlessly complicated, and at times, difficult to read. It is in a style that existed within both the 1900s and 1800s simultaneously. This style creates a space that urges conversation and critical thinking.

Camus is a philosopher, so his work resides within a study that is chock-full of thinkers; even so, his absurdism and the way he illustrates it in *The Myth of Sisyphus* is unlike any other mind, and entirely original. There is a plethora of aspects that create this originality. The way in which Camus presents his ideas prohibits readers from skimming his work's text. If the reader does not analyze the writing before a particular chapter, they will not comprehend what is being said within it. At times, he will reference an early chapter very late in his novel to reintroduce context, as he speaks on many topics in less than two-hundred pages.

Additionally, Camus may refer to other philosophers or stories to better explain his thinking. He declares, "And probably no one so much as Dostoevsky has managed to give the absurd world

familiar and tormenting charms,” using Dostoevsky, Camus strengthens his assertion by referencing a well-known philosophical author’s work and evaluating it. On the other hand, Sisyphus, the protagonist of *The Myth of Sisyphus*, is condemned to repeatedly roll a boulder up a hill for no reason indefinitely in Greek mythology, and he does so with little to no contest or anguish. He is the personification of Camus’s absurdism. As a result, he uses this story as the perfect expression of his philosophy.

The final aspect that makes him an original author is the disproportionate intellectual significance of his sentences. He exclaims, “In this unintelligible and limited universe, man’s fate henceforth assumes its meaning,” and follows it with an empirical, obscure example, “A horde of irrationals has sprung up and surrounds him until his ultimate end” (Camus, 21). The first sentence is significant to his definition of absurdism, but the second sentence is an example that throws the reader off with its placement and confusing nature. One would expect further elaboration. They do not get it; they only grow more bewildered.

## Conclusion

To conclude, Camus is an important individual in philosophical disciplines. Not because of his miraculous success as a formerly impoverished journalist, but because his authorial presence is unique, and his originality is clear. *The Myth of Sisyphus* is one of his most important novels, as it perfectly highlights both things. He writes with an active voice and a casual tone that pretends to be formal. The vocabulary he chooses to use is unnecessarily complex, and his phrasing is wildly convoluted. His sentence structure is sporadic and intellectually disproportionate.

Essentially, his main goal is to engulf his readers in dreadful inquiry. Moreover, Camus does not copy other texts and narratives; he simply uses them to enhance and exemplify his own writing, which cannot be browsed. He portrays his ideas by constructing their parts at the same time, while also calling upon earlier chapters. The result of this practice is a perplexed readership. This disorientation is purposeful. It is an intentional effect of his writing style that urges readers to slow down and engage with his content rather than merely consuming it. As a result, they will eventually reach a sort of enlightenment if they embrace thought provocation and fully examine each word he writes. The sole purpose of his novel is to challenge the human mind in its acceptance of the cold indifference that the world shows it. Camus's authorial presence and original vision of the metaphysical world are unmatched in accomplishing such a purpose.

## Works Cited:

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